

Laser therapy for melanoma

Laser therapy uses a high-intensity beam of light to destroy melanoma cells.

On this page

- [What is laser therapy for melanoma?](#)
- [Having laser therapy.](#)
- [About our information](#)
- [How we can help](#)

What is laser therapy for melanoma?

Laser therapy is sometimes used to treat small areas of skin affected by [melanoma](#) that has spread from where it started.

This laser treatment may not be available on the NHS in all areas of the UK. Your doctor or nurse can give you more information. We have more information about [treatment options for melanoma](#).

Having laser therapy

The treatment involves directing a small but strong beam of light at the affected skin. This destroys the melanoma cells. You can have the treatment more than once. Some people will have several sessions to treat a number of different areas of melanoma.

You can have laser therapy as an outpatient as a day case, which means you can go home afterwards. You may be given a local anaesthetic to numb the area first. You may feel some discomfort in the skin during and after treatment. Your doctor may advise you to take mild painkillers to help with these side effects. The treated area is usually covered with a dressing to protect it while it heals.

About our information

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our melanoma information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at cancerinformationteam@macmillan.org.uk

Michielin O, van Akkooi ACJ, Ascierto PA, et al. Cutaneous melanoma: ESMO Clinical Practice Guidelines for diagnosis, treatment and follow-up. *Annals of Oncology*. 2019; 30, 12, 1884-1901 [accessed May 2022].

Michielin O, van Akkooi ACJ, Ascierto PA, et al. ESMO consensus conference recommendations on the management of locoregional melanoma: under the auspices of the ESMO Guidelines Committee. *Annals of Oncology*. 2020; 31, 11, 1449-1461 [accessed May 2022].

Peach H, Board R, Cook M, et al. Current role of sentinel lymph node biopsy in the management of cutaneous melanoma: A UK consensus statement. *Journal of Plastic, Reconstructive & Aesthetic Surgery*. 2020; 73, 1, 36-42 [accessed May 2022].

Reviewers



This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer. It has been approved by Senior Medical Editor, Professor Samra Turajlic, Consultant Medical Oncologist.

With thanks to: Dr Stephanie Arnold, Consultant; Kerry Jane Bate, Advanced Nurse Practitioner; Dr Philippa Closier, Clinical Oncologist; Sharon Cowell-Smith, Macmillan Advanced Nurse Practitioner Skin Cancers; and Dr Benjamin Shum, Medical Oncologist.

Thanks also to the other professionals and people affected by cancer who reviewed this edition, and to those who shared their stories.

Our cancer information has been awarded the [PIF TICK](#). Created by the Patient Information Forum, this quality mark shows we meet PIF's 10 criteria for trustworthy health information.

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly

- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

Date reviewed

Reviewed: 01 October 2022 | Next review: 01 October 2025

ⓘ This content is currently being reviewed. New information will be coming soon.

Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live

Get help